

57channels

(And Nothin' Much On)

Like Bruce Springsteen did so many years ago, we find ourselves coming home to our HDTV only to find little to no HD content. At least we get more than 57 channels of nothing...

Ahmed Shaikh

Some time ago, Digit investigated the state of HDTVs in India. Back then, things were nebulous—it wasn't clear which HD technology to invest in. The TVs themselves were sparingly spotted in the retail wilderness—local HD content was a pipe-dream, and the prices were exorbitant to say the least.

Here we are and much has changed, and yet, little has changed. HDTVs are pretty much in every retail store—being pushed as eagerly as an air-conditioner or a washing machine would be to the mothers and the fathers of the world. The market has largely settled to backing the LCD technology, with Plasma tech playing second-fiddle, but nevertheless making its retail presence felt. Things are simpler thus. And cheaper, somewhat—you can pick up a fairly good quality and screen-size HDTV for about Rs 25,000. Cheaper still, if you know anyone in the Middle East. It is not exactly an impulse buy yet, but the various loans and offers on hand do make the jump that much more tempting.

There is still a little bit of caveat emptor, in picking up an HDTV. Not all flat-panel television sets are created HD,

and you still need to be very careful that you pick up a TV, that at least supports the 720p resolution. Anything lower and you are essentially getting duped—if you can't afford a model that does 720p, wait for the prices to drop as they invariably will. Do not settle for the 1080i-only TV sets, yes there are a small percentage of these out there as well. If you have the cash, go for the 1080p, but not with a screen size less than 50-inch—the higher resolution makes little difference for smaller screens. Here's something else you need to keep in mind while investing in a 1080p set—true HD-content, the 1080p kind, is hard to find. Mostly, your television will be upscaling content to fit the 1080p resolution. Upscaling is like taking a small photo, say of 320x240 pixels taken by your camera phone and then increasing its resolution to say 1024x768 using your computer. Mostly, the result looks bad, but this entirely depends on the quality of the TV's scaler—the piece of hardware that does the upscaling. The best thing to do is to test the TV with the kind of content you would be watching most frequently, right there in the retail store, before you pick it up. You are going to be spending upwards of Rs 50,000 for a set—so don't worry about inconveniencing the store—if they complain, take your business elsewhere.

All this brings to focus a sore point about the HD scene in India—the content, or rather, the lack of HD content. Here too, the scenario has improved, but not too much. We do have set-top boxes which are sometimes given away with HDTVs—these boast “DVD” resolutions or “MPEG4” quality, as if a video format or a video compression technique is any indication of the actual visual fidelity. Generally, these sets bring terrestrial TV shows in slightly better-than-normal-TV quality. Hardly any of the content here is widescreen, which means a less-than-ideal picture quality with stretched scenes and squat profiles. DVDs are widely available, and are more often, than not, a better means of enjoying that big screen you just bought. But where is the real HD content?

The good news here is that the HD-DVD format is dead and buried and there is only one clear format to back for HD content, that being Blu-Ray. So far, so good! But the bad news is that India is stuck with China, Mongolia and some other South Asian countries in the Blu-Ray region shuffle. It sucks because we are not in the regions that really matter and where all the HD-action happens—either with the USA and Japan region, or with the European region. It sucks more so, because for whatever reason, India has been stuck with a pitiful collection of Blu-Ray titles. Pitiful! It's best to not visit the Blu-Ray section of any major retail store, lest you want to tear your hair out at the frustratingly anaemic collection.

Stuck as we are with Region C in the Blu-Ray scheme of things, we cannot even import titles from online retailers such as Amazon.com, or Play-asia.com. Finally, where are the Blu-Ray players?! We have the PlayStation 3 and... the PlayStation 3. Sure the PS3 is a great device but a little competition here would be good. This is an international issue, not one just unique to India—the PS3, by-and-large is the best Blu-Ray player in terms of both affordability and quality of playback. So, if you are really serious about HD, consider importing a PS3 from the US, or Hong Kong.

So the point here is that unless you own an Xbox 360 or the PS3 and actively play games on these consoles, you could still skip on the HDTV. Unless, of course you are perfectly OK with watching regular television, the odd-DVD movie, or even the few Blu-Ray movies we have been blessed with. The rest of us should be patient, like we need to be with every technology, living in India.

The good news is that there is cooler tech than LCD and Plasma on the horizon! So let's dabble in a little bit of technological window-shopping and take a look at where the TV is headed.

The Sony PlayStation 3 is still the best Blu-Ray player out there. Now if we could only find some good Blu-Ray titles in India, we would be 30 per cent less sulky

The Challengers

LCD is the current king, with Plasma playing *Birbal*. If you want cheap and good, go for an LCD—their black level reproductions have markedly improved, ditto their viewing angles, and their popularity makes them cheaper than Plasma, on the whole. Plasmas though, are still the tech to pick if you want the absolute best visual quality—Pioneer's Kuro series is the best-of-the-best, with a Panasonic screen, not too far behind. But there are challengers to these current rulers.

FED: Straddling The CRT And The LCD

Field Emission Display is a self-luminescent display like CRT. Being self-lit, it offers superior brightness, contrast, and viewing angle compared to an LCD. Thus, FED displays feature the picture quality of a CRT and the flat profile of an LCD or a Plasma display.

Likelihood to take over the HD kingdom: Medium

LCoS: Bringing The Chips To Play

Liquid Crystal on Silicon was a tech quickly favoured and just as quickly abandoned by Intel. It uses a silicon chip at its heart, which is why Intel was interested in the technology. Using standard chip-making processes, an LCoS embeds LCD pixel units directly on the surface of a chip. The chip itself has all the circuitry needed to operate these LCD units. The big advantage with LCoS is that the technology improves as chip fabrication improves: with a smaller chip, you can add more LCD pixels, giving better resolution.

Likelihood to take over the HD kingdom: Low

Laser: A Potential LCD Killer

A Laser TV will essentially replace the traditional light-sources in rear-projection HD sets with, you guessed it, Laser light. As such, it is not a new technology, but an evolution of a current standard. It could potentially improve the quality of LCD and DLP sets. Laser sets promise to be thinner, consume less power, improve refresh rates, and extend a TV's life. They also promise to offer a wider range of colours—where the LCD reproduces about 50 per cent of the colour gamut visible to the human eye, a laser unit could go higher than 90 per cent colour gamut reproduction. This will make colours more 'life-like'.

Likelihood to take over HD kingdom: High

The Future Of TV

While the challengers are a small step forward in display tech, there is a whole range of displays being researched out there: some obvious, a few bizarre, while others are almost fictional.



Shrikishna Patkar



OLED displays and Laser backlit displays threaten to take the crown of Plasma HDTVs when it comes to image quality and black level reproductions